

The US Civil Rights Movement

Until the 1960s, laws in many of the southern states of the US allowed discrimination against Black Americans. Activists began a campaign to fight back against this oppression, which gained ground in the 1950s and 1960s. Known as the Civil Rights Movement, it demanded equality for all citizens.

In 1862, US President Abraham Lincoln issued the Emancipation Proclamation. This ended slavery in the US, but it did not ensure equality for Black people.

By the 1870s, laws came into force in some southern states that allowed local authorities to separate people on the basis of skin color, as long as they provided equal facilities for all. This led to separate spaces being created for Black people across the US—different schools and hospitals, and separate seating on buses, trains, and even in restaurants. The facilities created for Black people were always

inferior, and many public places and businesses refused to allow Black people to use their amenities at all. This discrimination spread to politics as well, with Black voters being denied entry to voting booths at election time.

In the mid-20th century, Black American activists began using peaceful protests, boycotts, and legal actions to demand equality for Black people. The movement led to the Civil Rights Act of 1964, which outlawed discrimination based on skin color, sex, religion, or national origin.



FACT

It was only in June 1967 that the US Supreme Court abolished a law that banned marriage between people of different races.

◀ BUS BOYCOTT

In the 1950s, Black people had to sit in the back of public buses by law in some areas. In 1955, Black American seamstress Rosa Parks sat in the first row of seats reserved for Black people on a bus in Montgomery, Alabama, and refused to give up the seat for a white person as the bus filled up. Her arrest sparked a year-long bus boycott by Black people, bringing attention to the unfair law.

CHILD IN TIME

In 1960, six-year-old Ruby Bridges became the first Black child to attend a previously all-white school in Louisiana. On her first days at school, Ruby had to be protected by government officials as there were threats against her. She grew up to become a civil rights activist.

